

Storm King's Thunder - Dubbo Table

Resume Checkpoint 4: Ear Seekers broken, Ardeep elves committed, Dripping Caves next

Prepared as a full handover for Claude/Marcus to take over as DM from the current pause point.

Current exact pause point

The Ear Seekers assault on Nightstone has ended. Gurrash and Norgra are dead. The surviving orcs have routed. Rond Arrowhome and seven Ardeep wood elf scouts stand outside the western moat. Rond has accepted Alphie's request to help rescue the captives in the Dripping Caves.

Resume before the coalition finalises: lowering the western drawbridge, whether to re-raise it after departure, horse allocation, marching order, and the cave split between south mouth and chimney route.

Hard DM instructions

- Strict 2014 D&D 5e RAW unless Marcus has explicitly made a table ruling. No 2024 rules.
- Storm King's Thunder is source of record. Table additions are canon only for this table.
- Do not roll for Alphie/Josh. Josh rolls Alphie's d20s and reports the result.
- Show d20 rolls and math in combat. Josh asked for transparent tactical play.
- Use the Nightstone map/grid for exact positioning when combat matters. Each square is 5 ft. Large mounts occupy 2 x 2 squares.
- No fudging. Pause is the safety word. Tone is serious, tactical, grounded, and honest.
- Marcus should openly correct mistakes. Josh prefers clean corrections over smooth hand-waving.

Source and rules corrections to preserve

- Level 2 Wizard/Cleric/Bard have three 1st-level spell slots, not 2nd-level slots.
- Wizard 2 has 3 cantrips, not 4.
- Alphie's Portent dice were 4 and 5. Both are now spent.
- Nightstone had 15 original goblins by source. Likely active after deaths/release: 12 goblins / 84 HP, scattered and uncoordinated.
- Xolkin source-correctly has six bandit subordinates, though table-current named focus is Pell, Joren, Maks, Tessa, Hask, plus one possible unnamed rider if restored.
- Xolkin has a flying snake in source. Table protocol assigned the snake to Torem as a plain alarm courier via Kella.
- Ardeep elves became involved through table play: Alphie saw them on Nat 20 Perception, invited them by horn, and persuaded Rond to help the cave rescue with Persuasion 23.

Latest scene chronology

Keep contact and public oath

Alphie and Dorrin crossed the temporary bridge. Kella stayed at the gate with weapon down. Sydiri, Alara, Torem, and Kaelen were alive with Lady Velrosa's body in the great hall. Dorrin healed Kaelen. Alphie publicly framed Xolkin as a temporary rescue ally, not an occupier. Xolkin swore rescue-only terms before Sydiri, Dorrin, and Lady Velrosa's body.

Level 2 milestone

Marcus awarded level 2 before the cave/orc sequence. Alphie became Wizard 2 Divination; Wren became Bard 2; Dorrin became Cleric 2 Life Domain.

Snake alarm protocol

Kella trained the flying snake to recognise Torem. If a hostile force threatens Nightstone while the rescue party is north, Torem sends one plain message north: force type, direction, approximate number. No code or faction business.

Ear Seekers spotted and fight chosen

Pell spotted movement. Alpie rolled Nat 20 Perception and saw the orcs plus Ardeep scouts. Alpie chose to defend Nightstone first rather than ride to the caves with a warband behind him.

Nightstone defence

Drawbridge raised, ranged positions taken, keep bridge rigged to be pulled, no chasing, no open-field fighting. The orcs entered the moat and were shredded by wall fire and later elf volleys.

Horn and elves

Sydiri sounded three short blasts at Alpie's order. Rond answered and the elves committed, moving to the orc rear.

Orc battle key moments

Dorin Blessed the wall shooters. Wren Faerie Fired Gurrash and Norga. Alpie used Portent 4 on Gurrash's failed save, Magic Missile plus Portent 5 to break Norga's Bless, and later killed Gurrash with Fire Bolt. Kella killed Norga. Dorin healed Sydiri. The orc force routed.

Rond persuaded

Alpie thanked Rond without offering payment, named the captive children and villagers, and asked for one more hour. Persuasion 23. Rond agreed that all eight elves will help at the cave mouth and revealed the chimney route.

Current allied roster and resources

Player characters

Character	Level	HP	AC	Slots/resources	Notes
Alpie J. Roane	Wizard 2 Divination	14/14	15 Mage Armor	0/3 slots; Portent spent	Cantrips only; Mage Armor ~7 hrs left; spellbook includes Grease + Feather Fall.
Dorin Stonebrook	Cleric 2 Life	17/21	18	0/3 slots; Channel Divinity unused	Preserve Life 10 HP pool still available; Potion of Heroism carried.
Wren	Bard 2	16/16	13	1/3 slots; BI 3/3	Known new spell: Feather Fall; Jack of All Trades; Song of Rest d6.

Coalition combatants for Dripping Caves

Combatant	Stat block	HP	Role
Kella Darkhope	Spy CR 1	27/27	Armed; ideal chimney/scout extraction.
Xolkin Alassandar	Bandit Captain CR 2	65/65	Oath-bound ally; strong melee reserve.
Joren	Bandit CR 1/8	11/11	Zhent with Xolkin.
Sydiri Haunlar	Guard-plus table NPC	22/22	Sergeant; local legitimacy; healed to full.
Alara Winterspell	Guard CR 1/8	11/11	Crossbow; steady young guard.
Rond Arrowhome	Scout CR 1/2	16/16	Ardeep leader; longbow; knows chimney.
7 Ardeep scouts	Scout CR 1/2	16 each	Longbows, stealth, cave knowledge.

Potential cave-side allied HP if all ride: 311 HP. This excludes horses and Nightstone stay-behind defenders.

Nightstone defenders staying behind

Defender	HP	Assignment
Pell	11	Western drawbridge / winch / bow.
Maks	11	Western drawbridge / winch / bow.
Tessa	11	Temple overwatch / village watch.
Hask	11	Horse line / rear security.
Torem Breck	11 max, wounded arm	Keep gatehouse anchor, crossbow left-handed, snake alarm holder.
Kaelen Zam	11 max, concussed but healed	Horse minder, non-combat.

Enemy and neutral audit

Ear Seekers - defeated/routed

- Gurrash dead; Norgra dead.
- About 14 orcs dead in moat/kill-zone.
- About 11 orcs scattered/routed: two south-east, three scouts south, six mostly toward the Ardeep hills.
- The orc warband is no longer a coherent force.

Remaining Nightstone goblins

Area	Goblins	HP
2D	Gwerk	7
2E	Larv, Snokk	14
4C	Pojo, Tot	14
4G	Blik, Flik	14
5B	Beedo, Vark	14
9	Jilk	7
10	Longo, Yek	14
Total active if none fled	12 goblins	84

Confirmed killed/removed: Derp dead; unnamed inn goblin dead; Gum-Gum released and not active hostile unless she returns. Rillix the tressym is neutral.

Dripping Caves threats

Threat	HP/CR	Notes
Hark	Goblin Boss, 21 HP, CR 1	Negotiable; self-preservation matters.
Two ogres	59 HP each, CR 2 each	Main danger; allied with Hark, not fully commanded by him.
Goblin clan	7 HP each	Exact room count should be checked from cave pages before combat.
Captive villagers	Fragile	Primary objective; not combatants.
Natural chimney	Tactical feature	Elves know it; ~50 ft descent to inner cave near captives.

Proposed Dripping Caves plan

Rond's two-prong plan is the best starting point: a quiet chimney extraction team while a visible south-mouth force fixes goblin attention.

South mouth visible force

- Alphie, Dorrin, Wren, Xolkin, Joren, Sydiri, Alara.
- Add four elves as external bow support if Rond agrees.
- Purpose: visible pressure, negotiation leverage, pin Hark's fighters away from captives.

Chimney extraction force

- Kella plus Rond and three elves is the clean default.
- Consider sending Dorrin only if healing near captives matters more than his shield at south mouth.
- Purpose: reach captives quickly, quietly, and begin extraction before Hark/ogres fully react.

Strategic caution

- Objective is prisoners out alive, not clearing the dungeon.
- Listen if Hark bargains; he is source-described as self-preserving rather than suicidal.
- Separate or distract the ogres where possible. They are more dangerous than goblins.
- Keep coalition terms public and clean: no Zhent claims, no elf/Nightstone provocation, no looting.

Open decisions for Josh/Alphie

- Drawbridge: lower for elves, then raise again after departure, or leave down with Pell/Maks ready?
- Horse allocation: which elves mount, which run, and who leads spare horses for villagers?
- Cave split: does Alphie lead south mouth or go with chimney extraction?
- Chimney order: who descends first with rope - Kella, Rond, or an elf scout?
- Spell scarcity: Alphie no slots, Dorrin no slots, Wren one slot. How cautious is the approach?
- Potion of Heroism: Dorrin still carries it. Drink before cave or save?
- Nightstone goblins: ignore until villagers are rescued, or assign defenders to watch known hotspots only?

Suggested first words on resume

Rond stands across the moat with his bow lowered but still strung. Behind him, seven Ardeep scouts wait in a loose line, faces unreadable beneath green-brown hoods. The western drawbridge stands upright between you and them, iron chains taut, Pell and Maks on the winches.

Xolkin looks from Rond to Alphie. "Lowering it lets them in. Raising it after we leave keeps the village sealed. Your call, Roane."

Sydiri wipes orc-blood spray from the parapet stone with the heel of her hand. "The caves are still north. Morak is still north."

Wren is quiet beside you, one hand on her viol case, looking at the elves like she's trying to decide whether this morning is going to become a song or a nightmare.

Rond calls once more across the moat: "Lower the bridge, Roane. If we ride, we ride now."

What does Alphie order?

Nightstone map reference

